

CHAPTER

6

Oral Presentation

Man reveals himself fully when he speaks.

Chapter Objective

To provide detailed guidance for acquiring the skill of effective oral presentation (including power point presentation) both in academic and professional settings, by using time-tested techniques and strategies of interactive group communication.

COMMUNICATION CORE

The acquisition of oral presentation skills is essential for success in a profession. Adequate planning and preparation in using one's voice, body language and visual aids is imperative for achieving the desired results in an oral communication situation. Body language (eye contact, facial expression, posture and gesture) plays a significant role. The proper use of the voice and the ability to modulate it to suit the various nuances of meaning are equally important. Apart from correct pronunciation, variation in pitch and tempo and fluency in delivery, free from speech mannerism, make the audience more receptive to a speech. To induce and sustain the interest of the audience, a judicious use of visual aids is advisable. Meeting is perhaps the most frequently used form for sharing information and experience, for discussing problems and discovering their solutions, and for generating confidence, enthusiasm, and a positive attitude within a professional organisation. Participation in meetings either as a chairperson or a member of the group needs adequate homework, alertness, tact and ability to generate discussion and respond spontaneously to the views of others.

In certain oral presentations in which a number of persons spread over a wide geographical area are expected to participate, a brochure is prepared and sent well in advance. It contains essential information such as background, theme, main topics for discussion, arrangements for board and lodging, etc.

You may be asked on occasions to present your reports orally and to take part in meetings, conferences, panel discussions and seminars. If you are an effective speaker, you will enhance

your prestige, influence decisions and come to occupy more important positions in your organisation. In fact, skill in oral presentation is an important equipment for life. The advice Shakespeare gave more than 350 years ago is still valuable and worth remembering:

Mend your speech a little,
Lest it may mar your fortune.

What was said earlier about effective writing applies equally to oral presentation. In this chapter, therefore, we shall discuss only those factors which are peculiar to oral communication. Since you will often work as part of a group, we are including here a section on conducting and participating in a meeting.

Detailed guidance on how to use non-verbal means in all forms of interaction and public speaking, including oral presentation, is given in Chapter 3.

CHARACTERISTICS

Let us first understand the nature of **oral presentation**. Is it different from a **lecture** and a **public speech**? It is true that in these three oral forms, one-to-many format is used. But oral presentation is the most interactive format and public speech is the least. In a lecture, the audience may ask questions but usually there is no intense interaction as in the case of oral presentation. The reason is that generally the audience in oral presentation is knowledgeable whereas in a public lecture it is not. **We may thus define oral presentation as a speech containing authentic and specialised or technical information or new ideas on a specific topic for a relatively smaller but knowledgeable audience.**

The matter presented is generally based on the results of a deep and detailed study of, or research on, a topic. Often audio-visual aids are used for illustration or in support of views and ideas. The presentation is followed by discussion, which is not merely a short question-answer session. There may be comments, explanations, clarifications and exchange of views among the members of the audience and the presenter. In fact, the speaker-audience divide tends to melt in the intensity of discussion.

PREPARATORY STEPS

To prepare for an oral presentation you would have to take more or less the same steps as for writing a report discussed in Chapter 19. We are repeating them here with certain necessary modifications to make the discussion self-contained.

- Gather the relevant material.
- Organise the material in proper sequence.
- Mark the material which you propose to emphasise.
- Decide the places where you would use a question, an anecdote or a story to fortify your argument or to illustrate your point.
- Decide on audio-visual aids, to be used by you.
- Prepare material you are going to display through slides, transparencies, etc.
- Prepare note cards corresponding to slides or transparencies.
- Prepare the material for distribution and decide on the points of time when you would like to distribute it to the audience.
- Collect information about the kind of audience you are going to address.

- If possible, inspect the venue for physical arrangements or gather information about it from the organisers.

AUDIENCE AWARENESS

Before you begin your talk, size up your listeners—their age, sex, background and interest. In most cases you will know beforehand who will constitute the audience. But even if you do not, a quick glance will enable you to sense whether they are a group of friendly or hostile people, whether their eyes are lit with eager expectation or they have been huddled into the room against their wish and are sitting with a look of ennui on their faces. A lot of common sense is required to become a good speaker. Use it to choose a suitable approach to your audience. In most cases if you speak directly, you will be listened to. Try to converse with them. Each listener should feel you are talking to him individually. No verbal fireworks are necessary to arrest attention. Instead, speak with conviction and sincerity about their immediate interest and something with which they are familiar and you will in all probability be able to lure them into listening. If the subject is drab, give it a personal touch. If necessary, dramatise certain ideas to break the barriers of communication. However, do not be too dogmatic; instead give the impression that you wish to share your views and ideas with the audience.

Another way to awaken an audience is to relate a joke. However, the effect of a joke depends on how you relate it. Try it first on friends, in smaller groups. If you do not get the expected response, drop it. Build it into the body of your speech in such a way that it appears to be a part of it and the audience receive it almost unprepared. Humour arising from personal anecdotes is perhaps the best. Some in the audience may have had similar experiences and they will quickly identify with you when you relate such a joke.

If you notice a listener smiling or whispering to a neighbour, do not feel disturbed, nor presume that he is criticising you. He may, in fact, be expressing his admiration for you. However, the best thing is to concentrate on ideas which you wish to communicate rather than on whether you are making a good impression.

PRESENTATION PLAN

The art of speaking is the fruit of persistent effort. There is no magic formula to make you an effective speaker. Adequate planning and preparation are essential for a successful presentation. In fact, thorough preparation is the best antidote for nervousness.

As far as possible do not read out a written speech word for word. A written speech seldom sounds fresh or vigorous. Do not memorize it either. The delivery of such a speech will not allow the necessary animation and spontaneity. Your presentation will lose flexibility and communication will suffer. Face to face interaction demands thinking and speaking and not a mere repetition of what you have learnt by rote.

However, if an extremely complex subject (e.g., a research paper for a seminar) is being presented to the members of a professional body, you may read the written material. But even here you should acquaint yourself with the material thoroughly. While reading, you should be able to lift your head and look at the audience after short intervals.

For most speaking situations, you should prepare adequate notes for consultation. The points should be arranged in the order in which you propose to present them and should have appropriate headings and sub-headings. You may cite references, quotations, names,

illustrations which you wish to use. Some speakers also write the introductory and closing remarks. If you think it necessary, indicate in the margin for your personal use the time that you are going to devote to each item. It is frustrating to hear a 25-minute introduction to a 50-minute talk.

Notes should be written neatly in large letters either on 3" × 5" cards or small-sized sheets. Large-sized sheets of paper and notebooks distract the audience's attention. Moreover, the sound produced by the turning of the pages, especially on the microphone, is annoying. Cards are handy and since they are thicker than the ordinary paper, their handling is easy.

You should consider yourself adequately prepared if on reading the notes you can quickly recall what you have to say on each item. Consult the notes frequently when you are speaking. There is no need to conceal the fact that you are consulting the notes. In fact, this may create a feeling among the listeners that you have taken pains to prepare for the occasion. A positive attitude will be generated and you will be listened to with respect.

VISUAL AIDS

It has been estimated that 11 per cent of what we learn is through hearing, 83 per cent through sight and the rest through the other three senses. Hence, visual aids can make your presentation more effective. The listeners usually feel stimulated and take more interest in what is being presented. Your explanation with the use of an aid can become more vivid and easily understandable. Some of the aids which can serve you well are maps, pictures, charts, motion pictures, slide and overhead projectors and a blackboard. Your choice will depend upon your topic, audience and the availability of the aid. But remember that too many aids may cripple the effect.

To get best results you should keep a few basic facts in mind.

- (i) Integrate the aid with the oral presentation and use it when you reach the relevant point.
- (ii) If possible, keep the chart, picture or map hidden or at an inconspicuous place until you need to refer to it.
- (iii) When in use, the visual aid should be displayed where everyone in the audience can see it. If necessary, examine the room beforehand and decide on the arrangement.
- (iv) Interpret it to the listeners and draw their attention carefully to what you want them to note.
- (v) Stand on one side and use a pointer, if necessary, while interpreting it.
- (vi) The aid should be sharp; emphasize only those aspects which you consider significant. Do not clutter it with too much information.
- (vii) If there is a blackboard behind you, see that it is clean. Write on it rapidly and legibly in large letters. Keep speaking while you write, if the entry is long. After you have finished writing, face the audience as you review or discuss the material. Erase entries which are no longer required and use coloured chalk for emphasis, if necessary.

USE OF CONNECTIVES

There are some presenters who use meaningless expressions to fill the time gap between one thought and another. In casual conversation these are not irksome but in public speaking they distract attention and impede the smooth flow of communication. Often this habit is

developed by speakers who fail to make an effective use of connectives. It is therefore essential to know the various kinds of connectives and their use in oral presentation. The ones that are frequently used are discussed below.

1. *Transitions* are words or phrases that indicate the end of one thought and movement to another. Examples:
 - *After having said that*, I must emphasize the significance of what I stated in the beginning.
 - We have been discussing the scope of the topic so far. I believe *it is time now* to focus attention on the main features.
 - The financial aspect of the proposal is only one of the considerations. *The others* are management and technical aspects.
 - In *addition* to formal instruction, an informal interaction between students and faculty is essential for enriching the process of education.
2. *Internal previews* are brief statements letting the audience know what the presenter would take up next for discussion. Very often these are introduced before the discussion of the main point in the speech. Example:
 - *After discussing the main provisions of the budget, we shall discuss its impact on the growth of agriculture and industry.*

This statement would prepare the audience to take in the presenter's views in the sequence indicated. It is, however, not necessary to give a preview of every main point. You should give it when you feel it would help the audience in keeping up with the track of your ideas.

3. *Internal summaries* help the audience to recall what they have heard upto that point of time. These are useful at the end of the discussion of a number of complicated points or explanation of a complex problem or situation. You have to decide at what stage of presentation you should give it. Remember that an internal summary is brief and precise, focussing attention on the most significant content of what you stated earlier and establishing a connection with what is to follow. Sometimes an internal preview follows an internal summary. This helps the audience to grasp easily what is being presented. Example:

In short, words are arbitrary symbols, abstractions of objects and ideas. And their value lies in the meaning they convey, not in how they look and sound.

4. *Signposts* are brief statements indicating where you are in your presentation. These may take different forms. The commonly used ones are numerical signposts and interrogative signposts. An example of each is given below:
 - (i) The first feature of the internal evaluation system is its transparency. The second feature is that it provides immediate feedback. The third feature is that it promotes continuous learning.

Each of the above statements would be followed by an explanation and illustrations.

- (ii) What are the causes of runaway population growth in our country? What steps should we take to solve this problem?

The first question will be followed by a discussion of the various causes and the second by a statement of measures to be taken to solve the population problem.

In addition to the above four types of connectives, a few frequently used phrases are listed below to help you integrate your presentation.

- (i) I would like to repeat the statement I just made ...
- (ii) The most significant aspect to which I wish to draw your attention is ...

- (iii) An understanding of this factor is essential for comprehending the rest of my presentation ...
- (iv) I would like you to recall what I said in the beginning ...
- (v) Be sure to keep in mind the point I just made ...

DISCUSSION SESSION

In almost every oral presentation, a certain amount of time (15 to 20 minutes) is set aside for discussion. To set the ball rolling, usually the presenter or the organiser invites the audience to ask questions either orally or in writing. The former saves time but the latter has the advantage of encouraging even shy participants to take part in the proceedings. Whatever be the method of asking questions, your response should be addressed to the entire audience. If the question is written, it should be read aloud and then answered. To generate discussion, you may ask other participants to express their views, after you have responded to the question. Sometimes, you should throw back the question to the audience and ask it to answer or comment. Just to intensify the discussion occasionally you may contradict an opinion or comment upon a viewpoint and encourage the concerned participant(s) to agree to his or their views. You should, however, take care to ensure that intensity does not degenerate into heat. There could be participants who enjoy disrupting the proceedings and embarrassing the speaker in the process. Take the aggressive participants tactfully by tickling their ego and then quickly moving on to the substance of discussion. And do remember to end the discussion within the time allotted for the purpose.

We would now like to quote in this context a statement by San Deep and Lyle Sussman in which the value of question as a tool of what discussion does has been powerfully brought out: **‘Questions are magic—they have the power to turn confusion into clarity, resistance into acceptance, division into consensus, frustration of not knowing what to say into the satisfaction of having said it.....’**

POWER POINT PRESENTATION

For Power Point presentation you will have to prepare slides. Through them you can display the key-points of your talk and related diagrams, drawings, pictures, photographs, etc. You may also include apt quotations and appropriate embellishments to make slides more effective and attractive. As the space on the slides is limited, the entire display material should be carefully selected and concisely presented. To give an example, let us assume that you have to give a talk on **How to prepare for an oral presentation?** For this presentation you may prepare the following slides.

Slide 1

Gather the relevant material

- ❖ From journals, books, magazines, etc.
- ❖ From the Internet
- ❖ Through mail questionnaire
- ❖ Through personal interview

Slide 2***Organise the material in proper sequence***

- ❖ Keeping the objective in mind
- ❖ Keeping in mind the nature of audience
- ❖ Ensuring that the sequence is logical
- ❖ Deciding which points to emphasize but remember...

Slide 3

"If you emphasize everything, you emphasize nothing!"

Slide 4***Identify the material for special effects***

- ❖ Anecdotes
- ❖ Stories
- ❖ Examples
- ❖ Illustrations

Slide 5***Know your audience***

- ❖ Size
- ❖ Age group
- ❖ Background, education, job profile, etc.
- ❖ Their expectations

Slide 6***Gather information about the venue***

- ❖ Size
- ❖ Seating arrangement
- ❖ Facilities available
- ❖ If possible, inspect the venue

Slide 7***Prepare material for distribution, if any***

- ❖ Cases for discussion
- ❖ Key points
- ❖ Quizzes

- ❖ Short exercises (application oriented)
- ❖ Keep material hidden from the audience's view and distribute only at suitable points of time

Slide 8***For time management***

- ❖ Allocate approximate time to be spent on each key-point
- ❖ Decide matter you would cut, if running short
- ❖ Keep questions ready, if running long
- ❖ But do not frequently look at your watch

Slide 9***To get ready for the performance***

- ❖ Construct and remember the first few sentences
- ❖ Recall the key points
- ❖ Construct and remember the last few sentences
- ❖ But the final presentation should look spontaneous

Slide 10***Rehearse the presentation***

- ❖ Simulate the actual presentation
- ❖ Get feedback on
 - Clarity in expression
 - Fluency of speech
 - Effectiveness of visuals
 - Time management

Slide 11***Remember***

“Preparation is the best antidote to nervousness and the best bet for success.”

Now we give below the **full text of a presentation based on the above slides.**

SAMPLE TEXT OF A PRESENTATION

Do you feel the fog in your throat when invited to start your presentation? We would be surprised, if you do not. If you do, you have a reason to be happy. Quite a number of speakers are like you. The fact is that, when we find an array of faces with expectancy in their eyes sitting

silently before us, we feel a load of responsibility on our shoulders. It is then natural to feel nervous in such a situation. But there is no need to be panicky. There is an element of energy present in the nervousness which, if properly harnessed, can help you make your presentation with agility, passion and conviction. Rest assured that if you prepare well, you can easily harness this energy and discharge your responsibility with confidence. Now, the question that automatically arises in our mind is 'How to prepare for an effective oral presentation?' Here are nine steps that we suggest. Just consider taking them next time you are asked to make an oral presentation.

Step One: Gather the relevant material. There are two types of sources from which you can do this: primary sources and secondary sources. Primary sources are those from which information is gathered by you first hand, that is, through mail questionnaire, personal and telephone interviews, experiments, observations, etc., or culled from files, company records, manuscripts, etc. The secondary sources are journals, magazines, books, newspapers and other publications in which information is available in organised form. All that you have to do is to select and use the information to support or illustrate your views and ideas.

Step Two: Organise the material. First, try to visualise the various aspects of the topic by splitting it in terms of points and sub-points. Think intensely until you become clear in your mind about the extent and depth of proposed coverage. The three parameters that would help you arrive at this decision are: the objective of the presentation, the nature of audience and the time available. Keeping these in mind classify the information you have gathered and listing your ideas in order of importance in an outline using indentations and decimal number system. As you know, each main idea constitutes a point, and each subordinate idea a sub-point. The sub-point illustrates, supports or explains the point. Thus, each sub-point is a sort of further break-up of a particular unit of thought. The outline thus prepared would serve as a road map, helping you move forward without losing direction and confidence. At this stage you also need to know which points or sub-points need to be emphasised. Mark them in your outline or note cards but remember: **'If you emphasise everything, you emphasise nothing'**.

Step Three: Identify the material for special effects. Experienced presenters often use **anecdotes, examples, stories, illustrations**, etc., to make their presentation effective. These should be appropriate and used at the right time in such a way that they add value to your presentation, keep the interest level high and relax the atmosphere, inducing receptivity of what is to follow. It is hard to identify stories or anecdotes relevant to all topics but if you can, write keywords or phrases in the outline or note cards to signal to you the time for relating them. The other two interest keepers, namely, examples or illustrations are not so difficult to use. In fact, you have been using them frequently in almost all courses of study. All that I want to remind you is that these too should be indicated in the outline or note cards that you may use for your presentation. Using them at the right time is of paramount importance.

Step Four: Know your audience. Let me first tell you a story. There was one Mr. Adil Baltiwalla who used to give every semester a series of lectures on '*marketing strategies*' to management students of a college located in another town. The class consisted of boys only as the college did not admit women students. But one day in the beginning of a new semester when Mr. Baltiwalla went to the class, he found a sea of feminine faces in front of him. He was

so nonplussed that he immediately walked out of the class murmuring to himself, 'Oh, there is no one in the class today!' Thus, howsoever well prepared you may be with your contents, you may fail miserably, if you do not know your audience. So try to garner as much information about the audience as is practically possible. Some of the facets of the audience which you need to know are as follows:

- **Profile in terms of age, education, job, etc.** This would enable you to choose appropriate examples, illustrations, etc.
- **Size in terms of number.** If you had planned for 20 and find 200 when you go to the venue, obviously you would have to make a quick adjustment in regard to your delivery, participation exercises, display of material, etc.
- **Audience mix.** You must know whether the group you are going to address is homogenous or it is a mix of various disciplines, functions and designations, etc.
- **Audience's expectations.** All topics have a number of dimensions. If you know what the audience expects from you, your presentation would have better chances of success.
- **Audience's awareness about you.** If your credibility is already established, you need not do it especially during the initial few minutes.

Step Five: Gather information about the venue. It is helpful to know the size of the room, seating arrangement, and the facilities available. If possible, visit the venue and see where you will stand, what arrangements have been made for display of material, etc. Incidentally, an inspection of the venue is likely to enhance your level of confidence.

Step Six: Prepare material (handouts) for distribution. The handout should be short and crisp. It may be just a list of additional points or a complicated diagram to which you would refer in your presentation. Never give the entire text of your presentation just in case you wrote it for practice and rehearsal. If the organisers want this to be done, distribute it after you have completed your presentation. Timing of material distribution is very important to ensure attention of the audience to what you say.

Step Seven: Time management. Lord Birkebt once said: 'I do not object to people looking at their watches when I am speaking, but I strongly object when they start shaking them to make sure they are still going.' Surely, you would not like to be caught in a situation of this kind. One way of managing time is to allot time to the coverage of each slide. The material on the slide would help you decide the amount of time you would like to spend on it. It is advisable to keep photocopies of your slides with you in the form of note cards. You may write the amount of time on the top of each note card.

Step Eight: Get ready for the performance by visualising it. Recall the points and sub-points you have noted in the outline and generate thoughts on each and construct sentences (in your mind.) in which you would use to express them. Construct and remember a few opening sentences and those with which you would like to end your presentation.

Step Nine: Simulate the actual presentation. before a group of your friends and obtain their feedback, specially regarding clarity in expression, fluency of speech, effectiveness of visual aids and time management.

If you take the nine steps we have just discussed you would definitely do well in your presentation. Nobody is born with presentation skills. These have to be acquired with sustained efforts. Remember, **preparation is the best bet for success. And to do your best tomorrow, do your best today.** Before I close, all that remains to be said is a sincere thank you, ladies and gentlemen, for having listened to me patiently.

CHECKLIST

Presented below is a checklist of significant aspects of oral presentation. These would help you remember the points you should bear in mind in order to make your oral presentation effective.

Pronunciation

1. Is the pronunciation of individual sounds clear and proper?
2. Have the stresses been put on the right syllables?
3. Is the intonation appropriate?

Delivery

4. Is the presenter poised and relaxed?
5. Is the voice animated, vibrant and well-modulated?
6. Is the volume of voice according to the size of the audience?
7. Are the pauses at the right places?
8. Is the rate of delivery normal, that is, approximately 150 words per minute?

Body Language

9. Has the presenter a pleasant personality?
10. Is his posture proper?
11. Does he make appropriate gestures?
12. Is he dynamic?
13. Does he maintain eye contact with the entire audience?

Organisation of Matter

14. Is the introduction attractive?
15. Does it tell what the presentation contains?
16. Is the objective clearly stated?
17. Is the body of speech properly structured and integrated?
18. Are the points logically ordered?
19. Are the arguments supported by details and illustrations?
20. Is the information presented authentic and accurate?
21. Is the conclusion related to the objective?
22. Does it summarise the main points?
23. Does it clearly signal that the presentation is coming to an end?